

WHERE DID ALL THESE RUINS COME FROM?

A SHORT HISTORY OF THE POST-APOCALYPTIC GENRE

The post-apocalyptic imagination didn't begin with gaming – it arrived fully formed, anxious and vivid, from the literature and cinema of the mid-twentieth century, shaped almost entirely by one specific fear: the bomb.

Mary Shelley's *The Last Man* (1826) is often cited as the first true post-apocalyptic novel, a plague narrative that imagines the extinction of humanity by the twenty-first century. But the genre's cultural DNA was most decisively written in the 1950s, when atomic testing made the end of the world feel not like philosophy but like meteorology. Richard Matheson's *I Am Legend* (1954) established the template: one survivor, a transformed world, the slow reckoning with what humanity means when almost all humans are gone.

Film accelerated everything. *On the Beach* (1959), *Planet of the Apes* (1968), *Mad Max* (1979) – Hollywood discovered that rubble was cinematic and moral simultaneously. The wasteland became shorthand for consequence: this is what happens when we go too far. Nuclear anxiety had found its aesthetic, and that aesthetic was extraordinarily durable.

Gaming entered the genre tentatively. Text adventures and early RPGs offered stat-driven survivalism in nuclear deserts, establishing conventions – scavenging, faction politics, radiation as both danger and metaphor – that would define the form for decades. When Brian Fargo's team built *Wasteland* in 1988, they were working from Cormac McCarthy's bleakness and the *Mad Max* films in equal measure, blending grim survivalism with a wry absurdism that felt distinctly American.

Then came *Fallout* in 1997. Interplay's isometric RPG took that template and injected it with pitch-black comedy, retrofuturist aesthetics, and a genuinely

sophisticated morality system. The bomb's aftermath was rendered as dark satire – a 1950s America that got exactly what it was afraid of, preserved in amber and irony. This tonal complexity, the idea that apocalypse could be simultaneously horrifying and funny, became gaming's particular contribution to the genre. Cinema had mostly played the ruins straight. Games made them strange, and playful, and strangely habitable.

The 2000s brought two decisive expansions. First, the Eastern European tradition – *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.*, *Metro*, the Polish and Czech games scenes – brought a rawer, less satirical weight to the wasteland. These were games from countries with living memory of catastrophe, Soviet collapse, and real nuclear disaster, and it showed in their texture. The genre gained gravity it hadn't quite had before. Second came the spread of post-apocalyptic themes beyond action-RPGs into survival games, horror, literary adventure, and eventually pure political testimony. This *War of Mine* arrived in 2014 as proof that the apocalypse could be a form of witness, not entertainment.

Today the genre is everywhere – in battle royales, in narrative adventures, in indie darlings and blockbuster trilogies. Its dominance reflects something real about where collective anxiety has settled: not just the bomb now, but climate, pandemic, political fragmentation. The list of things that could end the world has grown considerably since 1954. The ruins have multiplied to match our fears.

And yet players keep returning to them. Keep rebuilding. Keep finding, in the waste, a strange and stubborn kind of hopefulness. That, perhaps, is what the genre was always really about – not the end of the world, but the extraordinary human insistence on what comes after it.

know your name. *Death Stranding* is the most divisive game on this list and possibly the most important. In a genre obsessed with conflict and scarcity, it asks: what if the post-apocalyptic response was simply to reconnect? To build, to carry, to help?

The America of *Death Stranding* has been severed by the Stranding –

an extinction event that blurred the boundary between life and death – and Sam Porter Bridges must walk it back together, one delivery at a time. The asynchronous multiplayer, where other players' structures appear silently in your world, is the most moving mechanic in modern gaming. You cross a mountain and find a lad-

der someone left for you. You don't know who. You never will. You press a button to say thank you, and the game registers it as a like, and somewhere someone playing their own game gets a small notification that their ladder helped a stranger. Kojima made his masterpiece. The apocalypse ends. The games don't. *